

THE ALPS

The mountainous heart of Europe

With an area of just under 77,000 sq miles (200,000 sq km), and 82 summits higher than 13,120 ft (4,000 m), the Alps form a natural climate barrier, dividing Europe into a cool, wet north and a warm, drier south. The mountains arc from France and Italy in the southwest to Austria in the east, and extend into eight countries. They rise from sea level to a peak of 15,771 ft (4,807 m)—the top of Mont Blanc, which straddles the French-Italian border.

Bountiful valleys

The Alps have several habitats, including glacial lakes, valleys, forests, high alpine meadows, and the slopes above the tree line. The meadows were created by specialist alpine plants colonizing rocky soil exposed by retreating glaciers. The region has been populated since prehistoric times, and a long history of mainly subsistence agriculture has changed the nature of the

valleys and mountainsides to quite high levels. However, the steepness of the terrain and the need for trees to block avalanches means that large areas remain in a natural state. The Alps, therefore, support a rich diversity of plant and animal life, which, because of their location, are well studied. Of 13,000 plant species, 388 are endemic, and the Alps are also home to around 30,000 animal species.

Changing attitudes to wild carnivores and increasing forest cover are reflected in the gradual expansion of tiny remnant populations of gray wolf, European brown bear, and Eurasian lynx. However, these recoveries are not without problems—livestock, without protection, are easy prey for predators.

